
The Countywide Benefits Team

Who are the Countywide Benefits Team?

The Team is a countywide service which is part of the Maximising Independence Service (MIS). It comprises of a Senior Benefits Officer and four FTE Benefit Officers.

What does the Team do?

The Team provides benefit advice to people to ensure they are receiving the benefits they are entitled to and help to maximise their income and enable them to live as independent as possible. They work mostly with adults who require independent advice to increase their income. This enables them to pay for care or services that they may need to maintain their independence.

The Team provides training on benefits to our Adult Social Care and Health colleagues to help them identify people that may require our advice. The Team also delivers training and support to partner organisations on welfare benefit issues.

The Team represents the authority on benefit issues with partner agencies, deliver talks to carer groups, and publish factsheets and web pages on benefits.

The service is telephone based. However, if face to face support is necessary, the Team can refer on to a partner organisation or the DWP. They will first determine that there is an entitlement to benefit so that home visits for help such as form filling are reserved for the most vulnerable who really need it.

Challenging benefit decisions and appeals

The Team can support people to challenge a DWP decision on their benefit if they feel it is unfair.

The advisers can talk through the decision and advise on the next steps to take should they wish to challenge it via a Mandatory Reconsideration. If this is not

successful, they will provide advice on how to take their case to a formal Tribunal and explain what to expect.

The Team are affiliated with Nottingham Law School Legal (NLS) who they can refer to them for tribunal representation if they believe there is a case for formal appeal. The FRU require a minimum of two weeks' notice in order to prepare for a tribunal and the claimant must have already been given an appeal date.

How to refer to the Countywide Benefits Team

As an ASCH worker you can make a referral to the Countywide Benefits Team by either:

Simply adding us as a 'next action' on any mosaic form or workflow that you are already working on. There is an option to 'send immediately' so that you do not have wait until you finish your own workflow.

OR

If you do not have a piece of work open, you can complete a Benefits Team Referral form from the person's front screen on Mosaic under the 'start' menu.

Complete the form as fully as possible and send directly to the Countywide Benefits Team in the 'next actions' screen.

There is a duty worker available each day who will allocate cases and be available to answer any queries. Referrals aim to be dealt with within 10 working days or 48 hours for case's marked Priority 1.

Referrals must only be marked as a Priority 1 case if the person requires urgent advice for example; they have a tribunal or appeal date, or their benefits have been stopped or person has no income, or where advice is required to aid with other imminent social care decisions such as supported living placements and urgent care needs and or end of life support.

The team and duty worker can be contacted for general queries via our (internal only) email address which is Benefits.Team@nottscc.gov.uk.

Factsheets

- [28 day linking rule factsheet \[PDF\]](#)
- [Attendance allowance factsheet \[PDF\]](#)
- [Carer's allowance factsheet \[PDF\]](#)

- [Challenging a benefit's decision factsheet \[PDF\]](#)
 - [Council Tax discounts factsheet \[PDF\]](#)
 - [Education and Universal Credit \[PDF\]](#)
 - [New style employment and support allowance factsheet \[PDF\]](#)
 - [New style Job Seeker's Allowance factsheet \[PDF\]](#)
 - [Pension Credit factsheet \[PDF\]](#)
 - [Personal Independence Payment \(PIP\) factsheet \[PDF\]](#)
 - [Transitions factsheet \[PDF\]](#)
 - [Universal Credit factsheet \[PDF\]](#)
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